

PHIL 402 – Introduction to Phenomenology
Part I – Husserl's Founding of Phenomenology
Week 3 – *The Transcendental Turn to Genetic Phenomenology*

1. Transcendental Argument and the Kantian Legacy of Phenomenology *Notes:*

Transcendental arguments are a special kind argument that are concerned with conditions of possibility for something's being the case.

The sorts of 'things' here tend to be obvious. For example, Kant thought that it was obvious that we could make judgments, that is, have propositional attitudes of the form $\langle S \text{ is } P \rangle$. The question then becomes, in virtue of *what* is it the case that we are capable of entertaining judgments of different sorts? What are the conditions of possibility for such judgments to occur?

The argument structure tends to look like this:

1. It is the case that P [where p here is something obvious that even an entrenched skeptic could get on board with].
2. Q is a necessary condition for P.
- C. Therefore, it is the case that Q.

Different kinds of transcendental philosophers argue for (2) in different ways.

Kant: Uses conceptual analysis. He analyzes the conceptual structure that we assume we have when making judgments in order to explain how judgments are possible.

Husserl: Uses phenomenological description. He is trying to articulate the latent structure of those conscious processes that enable us to have experiences as of a world of mind-independent things.

Transition from Static Phenomenology to Genetic Transcendental Philosophy:

- a. From Static to Genetic: we are no longer concerned with analyzing simply the ideal structures of those cognitive processes that allow us to know mathematical and logical truths, but the entire field of mental processes, especially perception.

Quote: Through this exposition of the concept 'phenomenon' we obtain a preliminary conception of a general phenomenology, viz., a science of objective phenomena of every kind, the science of every kind of object, an 'object' being taken purely as something having just those determinations with which it presents itself in consciousness and in just those changing modes through which it so presents itself. It would be the task of phenomenology, therefore, to investigate how something perceived, something remembered, something phantasied, something pictorially represented, something symbolized looks as such, *i.e.*, to investigate how it looks by virtue of that bestowal of

sense and of characteristics which is carried out intrinsically by the perceiving, the remembering, the phantasying, the pictorial representing, etc., itself (*tPR*, 127).

b. From merely descriptive to fully transcendental phenomenology

The phase of Husserl's thinking is fully transcendental in that he thinks that it is on account of the processes of conscious intentionality that the world appears to us at all. Note, this is not idealism in the strong sense of affirming the view that the world itself is a mental process. Instead, it is the view that the conditions of possibility for anything appearing any way at all, for anything to *seem* to be in any way whatsoever, involves a process of conscious intentionality whereby what might be known is constituted by the experience that knows it.

2. Phenomenological Method and its Purported Purity

Husserl sees phenomenology as a kind of *infinite task* whose methods are completely *pure* of any overlap with the procedures of empirical science (psychology or otherwise):

Quote: "A new fundamental science, pure phenomenology, has developed within philosophy. This is a science of a thoroughly new type and endless scope...All philosophical disciplines are rooted in pure phenomenology, through whose development, and through it alone, they obtain their proper force" (*tPR*, 124).

An Analysis of Perception:

Quote: The manner in which the object is given within each of the single intuitions belonging to this continuous consciousness may vary constantly; for example, the object's sensuous 'looks' — the way in which the object always 'looks' different at each approach or remove and at every turning, from above or below, from left or right — may be forever new in the transition from one perception to continuously new perceptions. In spite of that, we have, in the way in which such series of perceptions with their changing sensuous images take their courses, intuitive consciousness not of a changing multiplicity but rather of one and the same object that is variously presented. To put it differently, within the pure immanence of such consciousness one unitary 'phenomenon' permeates all the manifolds of phenomenal presentation (*tPR*, 125).

We see a number of claims being made here:

- There is a kind of appearance/reality structure in our perception.
- There are facts about our experience that we often miss.
 - There is invariance amidst constant change in our perceptual experience.
 - As agents, we contribute to the nature of our experience by what we do and this has an impact on how things appear to us.

Phenomenology has an Attitude:

In order to understand *why* we often miss out on these perceptual processes, Husserl makes a distinction between two kinds of *attitudes*.

Consider the following perceptual experience as an example and then we will follow Husserl in thinking about this experience from the perspective of both the *natural* and *transcendental phenomenological attitudes*:

“Let us suppose that in a garden we regard with pleasure a blossoming apple tree, the freshly green grass of the lawn, etc. It is obvious that the perception and the accompanying liking are not, at the same time, what is perceived and liked” (*tPR*, 136).

3. The Natural Attitude

Quote: In the natural attitude, we experience, among other things, processes in Nature; we are adverted to them, observe them, describe them, subsume them under concepts. While we do so, there occur in our experiencing and theorizing consciousness multiform conscious processes which have constantly changing immanent constituents...A person in the natural attitude, however, knows nothing of this. He executes the acts of experiencing, referring, combining; but, while he is executing them, he is looking not toward them but rather in the direction of the objects he is conscious of (*tPR*, 128).

So, in applying this attitude to our above example, we get the following:

“In the natural attitude, the apple tree is for us something existing in the transcendent realm of spatial actuality, and the perception, as well as the liking, is for us a psychical state belonging to real people” (*tPR*, 136)

A change of attitude:

- In order to break out of the natural attitude we perform a kind of bracketing or *epoché* which is to suspend our habitual commitment to the actual mind-independent nature of that which we perceive in the world of nature.
- Husserl also calls this a ‘phenomenological reduction’, because we reduce the content of experience to only its appearance to consciousness, without any further supposition about the causal order in nature which makes the content of our experience, or the objects represented by it, objectively real.

In this way, “...phenomenological reduction is the method for effecting radical purification of the phenomenological field of consciousness from all obtrusions from Objective actualities and for keeping it pure of them...Nature, the universe of spatiotemporal Objectivity, is given to us constantly; in the natural attitude, it already is the field for our investigations in the natural sciences and or our practical purposes. Yet, nothing prevents us from putting out of action, so to speak, any believing in the

actuality of it, even though that believing continues to occur all the while in our mental processes” (*tPR*, 129).

4. The Transcendental Phenomenological Attitude

Quote: Let us now go to the transcendental phenomenological attitude. The transcendent world receives its ‘parenthesis,’ we exercise the *epoché* in relation to positing its actual being. We now ask what, of essential necessity, is to be discovered in the complex of noetic processes pertaining to perception and in the valuation of liking (*tPR*, 136).

- What Husserl is saying here is that there is a way of looking at our experience that regards that which shows up in it as the result of conscious processes rather than just the causal interactions of natural kinds with our sensory receptors. Experience is an achievement of the conscious subject, not just something that happens as the causal upshot of natural processes discernible to the empirical sciences.

NOTE: There is a risk of interpreting the phenomenological attitude as a kind of introspective retreat into an interior world, a kind of ‘Cartesian Theater’ of the mind. This would be a mistake.

Against Internalism:

“And yet, so to speak, everything remains as of old. Even the phenomenologically reduced perceptual mental process is a perceiving of ‘this blossoming apple tree, in this garden,’ etc., and, likewise, the reduced liking is a liking of this same thing. The tree has not lost the least nuance of all these moments, qualities, characteristics, *with which it was appearing in this perception*, with which it is appearing as ‘lovely,’ ‘attractive,’ and so forth ‘in’ *this liking*” (*tPR*, 137).

- This is why the focus is on *attitudes*. By changing our operative perspective on our experience, we can gain insight into its structure that we would otherwise not have.
- The point is not to retreat to some internal mental theater, but to recognize that the totality of our experience is, from the perspective afforded us by the phenomenological transcendental attitude, an accomplishment of consciousness and disclosed to us through the architecture of our various forms of intentionality.

5. Noesis and Noema

When we adopt the phenomenological attitude we gain experiential access to not only the varying contents of our experiences, but the acts themselves which disclose those contents.

Husserl calls the experiential acts we live through *noesis* or *noetic* processes and their content or the meaningful objects that we are acquainted with in virtue of living through mental acts of different sorts, *noema* or *noematic* features of experiential acts.

The job of the phenomenologist is to describe the structure of the relationship between these two aspects of experience and the experiential ego around which they are organized.

On Transparency:

- In contemporary philosophy of mind, a lot of focus is put on the so-called 'transparency' of experience. The idea here is that when we have experience, we have access only to the content of that experience as it is embodied in the objects that we perceive.
- Husserl's approach is a flat-out denial of the transparency thesis. On his account, we experience both the content of experience, and the mental acts by which that content is disclosed to us, as subjects.

Attention and Three levels of Phenomenological Analysis:

- In addition to there being a noematic and noetic level of analysis from within the Phenomenological attitude, there is also an egoic level as well.
- Husserl's emphasis on the phenomenological ego is in stark contrast with his analysis in the *Logical Investigations*, where he was decidedly non-egoic in his approach
 - So what changed?
 - Answer: **attention**
- In his genetic phase, Husserl comes to a deeper appreciation of the role of *attention* in shaping the contours of the phenomenal field of experience. This leads him to posit a phenomenological ego from which attentional 'rays' originate.

Quote:

The ray of attention presents itself as emanating from the pure Ego and terminating in that which is objective, as directed to it or being diverted from it. The ray does not become detached from the Ego; on the contrary, it is itself an Ego-ray, and remains an Ego-ray. The 'Object' is struck; it is the target, it is put into a relation to the Ego (and by the Ego itself) but is not 'subjective.' A position-taking which bears the Ego-ray is, because of it, an act of the Ego itself; the Ego does or undergoes, is free or conditioned. The Ego, as we also said, 'lives in such acts. Its living in them signifies not the being of some 'contents' or other in a stream of contents, but rather a multiplicity of describable manners in which the pure Ego, as the 'free being' which it is, lives in certain intensive mental processes, those which have the universal *modus cogito*. But the express, 'as a free being,' indicates nothing else than such modes of living pertaining to freely going out of itself or freely withdrawing into itself, spontaneous doing, being somehow affected by Objects, suffering, etc. (*tPR*, 143-4).

Some things to note:

- In virtue of our capacity to deploy our attention, the *noetic* and *noematic* structure of our experience changes.
 - Consider the example of enjoying the perceptual experience of a beautiful garden. Attention changes how things (*noemata*) appear as well as the perceptual act itself (*noesis*) can be more or less engaged with its object by how attention is deployed. The deployment of attention also represents a modification of the self (phenomenological ego) as that which directs the attention in some way or another.
- Attention is a process. As such, it is temporally extended. If attention is essential to our analysis of the *noematic*, *noetic*, and egoic aspects of experience, then we must analyze the structure of our temporal experience itself.

6. Time and the Genetic Turn

The phenomenological conception of experience that Husserl articulates in his *genetic* phase is dynamic and temporal in nature.

This approach characterizes experience as a kind of temporally extended process in which episodes of perception and thought overlap and flow into each other in a dynamic way in commerce with a meaningfully given environment.

Husserl's account of time-consciousness is a way of characterizing this flow at its most general level. He is trying to articulate an account of the temporal structure of any possible experience.

What's in an instant? What counts as now?

Colloquially, we tend to think of time as having a knife-edge present. If I asked you to define *now* you would probably snap your fingers. Husserl's account of the present moment is a bit more nuanced than this.

The Structure of Now - Consider Husserl's favorite example of listening to a melody:

With the apprehension of the sound appearing now, heard as if now, primary remembrance blends in the sounds heard as if just previously and the expectation (protention) of the sound to come. Again, the now-point has for consciousness a temporal halo which is brought about through a continuity of memory" (*tPR*, 113).

NOTE: For Husserl, the *now* is actually thick, rather than knife-edged, and is structured by three connected moments, whose synthesis constitutes the lived present of temporal experience.

Primal Impression - Occurent present moment experience, that in virtue of which the world is disclosed to conscious awareness.

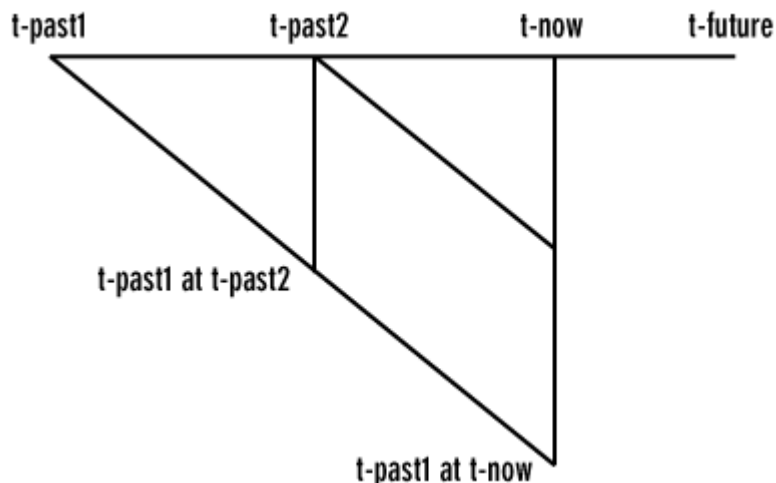
Retention - The elapsed phase of present experience, the just-past of the present in virtue of which the arising of current experience is experienced as continuous with that which has just occurred.

- Husserl often calls retention 'primary memory' and it has to be contrasted with what we ordinarily call 'memory'. Retention is a way in which the immediately past is still connected to the present such that the thickness of the temporal *now* can be sustained.

Protention - The indefinite orientation of the present moment to the future; that in virtue of which the unknown future is experienced as an open possibility that is both imminent (about to happen) and immanent (operating from within) in present experience.

Unity: The unified operation of protention, primal impression, and retention underlies our experience of the present moment as having temporal width.

- Primal impression is the continuous intending of the new, even if it be only the newly unchanging (as in the case of a continually sounding tone).
- Retention is the continuous holding onto the present as slipping away and sinking into the past.
- Protention is the continuous going beyond the present as opening into the future.



Quote: "...every act of memory contains intentions of expectation whose fulfillment leads to the present. Every primordially constitutive process is animated by protentions

which voidly constitute and intercept what is coming, as such, in order to bring it to fulfillment” (*tPR*, 120).

- This threefold structure is invariant and present synchronically as a unified whole throughout the course of experience. Although the specific experiential contents of this structure change from moment to moment, the structure itself does not (unless consciousness suffers a radical breakdown).

Contrast: Protention and retention are importantly different from expectation and memory. The latter of these are non-present centered cognitive functions. By contrast, protention and retention are intentional functions of consciousness by which present experience is structured.

- In addition to the content of conscious experience, we also experience consciousness itself as a dynamic temporal process that discloses the present by retaining the just elapsed past and the not yet arrived future.

Quote: “The foreground is nothing without the background; the appearing side is nothing without the non-appearing. It is the same with regard to the unity of time-consciousness — the duration reproduced is the foreground; the classifying intentions make us aware of a background, a temporal background” (*tPR*, 122).

Standing-Streaming:

- There is a potential for an infinite regress in the reflective capacities of consciousness.
- We are aware of the diachronic unity of objects which exist in objective time, in virtue of our awareness of the temporal structure of our own experience, the intentional acts of time-consciousness that help to constitute the experiences we have of objects (like melodies).
- Our experience of those intentional acts of consciousness exist in a kind of internal time. In virtue of what then are we aware of the latter? Must we posit a second order experience which takes our first-order three-fold temporal consciousness as an object? Husserl's answer to this problem is to posit a kind of absolute substratum of temporal consciousness. This means that we have three types of temporality:

Temporal objects - temporally constituted by objective time

Experiences of those objects - allow us to behold temporal objects through the threefold structure we have previously discussed.

Experiencing the intentional acts themselves - constituted by a standing-streaming absolute flow of time consciousness.